

As he puts it: "If you really want to learn computer science, you will not learn anywhere else other than via Linux. It teaches you a whole lot. Every day."

Rip Van Winkle

When we reminisced recently, both of us jokingly said we felt like Rip Van Winkle. Coming back to civilisation twenty years later, and being surprised to note how the "world has changed." Today, says Partha, everyone swears by Linux. People, particularly those in the academic field, "have taken well to FOSS. They want something reliable."

He argues: "People once thought that if it was free, there must be something wrong with it. Today almost everybody I meet swears by it and says it's either Linux or nothing. Particularly those in the academic field have a lot of respect and admiration for Linux. They want something reliable and honest, which they can copy and freely give to their students."

"Sharing is a very human emotion. Everybody wants to share. Even when sitting with people you do not know in a train, sharing is a human instinct. So why should it not be so with computer science, and with software?" he asks.

How does he see the strengths and weaknesses of the two-decade-old campaign in India? He quips: "I would not say we've failed. But we have not learnt how to sell ourselves. Basically, Linux people are poor sales people."

He remembers Naidu, who worked for AT&T, and brought him a set of magazines and Linux distros. "The first distro I installed with my own hands was Slackware, given to me by Naidu. It was Kernel 1, maybe some 25 years ago. Slackware was a complete no-graphics distro."

We spoke about those who had shaped the FOSS world in India then. Among others, Atul Chitnis, Raj Mathur, Prof G. Nagarjuna, Prakash Advani, expat Indians in Singapore and

Australia, and even a Hindu priest who was also a Debian hacker in the US!

He recalls Prof Rajeev Sanyal of IIT Hyderabad. "I had a CD but could not share it with him, as I didn't have a CD burner (which were rare to come by then). So Prof Rajeev (and others wanting to borrow it) would send their men, and the CD would crisscross Hyderabad because someone or the other needed to share the software. That's how we started it all. It's an unbelievable story. If you want something badly enough, there are people who will help you. I'm happy I went through all this."

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Adult education

Was he then one of the first Linux users in the country? "I don't think so," he says with modesty. But he believes he was one of the first Linux learners. "Talk about adult education, and I'm a good example," says he, with a laugh.

He recalls the youngsters who taught him and are now in New Zealand. Doc Partha says his 'teacher' in Linux was Srinivasan, a young man two years junior to his own son.

Punched cards

Dr Partha did his PhD thesis during the punched-card days, from the Institut National Polytechnique de Grenoble, France, located on the France-Italy-Switzerland border. "I have punched cards right here, at home. To write a 200-line FORTRAN project took me one box of punched cards," he recalls.

That was in 1980, after which he worked in China. He's been in the software industry since the 1980s — in corporations, as an independent entrepreneur, and a university teacher. Partha has also taught in France, Macau, Thailand, Indonesia, Germany, Spain, Poland, Nepal, China, and India. Wow! His last assignment was in 2015, in Kathmandu, the scenic city he left after the major earthquake that very year.

In Kathmandu, he taught cryptography for four years. Cryptography's best tools are in Linux, he says.

"In fact, I started life (in computing) with a Multics machine," he notes. Linux follows a POSIX (Portable Operating System of UNIX) standard. This is a family of standards specified by the IEEE Computer Society for maintaining compatibility between operating systems. On its first page, the book outlining this standard acknowledges some 200 contributors. His is the only India-based Indian name there, he says proudly.

'Linux in a Teaspoon'

One of Doc Partha's much-remembered works is called 'Linux in a Teaspoon'. It is an introduction to all aspects of Linux. "It starts by saying, 'Don't use Linux if you think it's not user-friendly, or if you want to play games.' I began that work by giving people ten reasons why they should not use Linux," he says.

Back then, tonnes of bytes of GNU/Linux resources were packed into a single CD. It contained all the stories, links and downloaded material related to Linux. "In those days, the Internet was not popular [or easy to access in countries like India]. So I had to make a CD, and distribute it free of cost to everyone around. Whichever course I conducted, I would distribute the CD free of cost."

This was a simple-yet-radical idea in its time — collating and freely sharing knowledge, in a way that made it even easier to spread and proliferate it.

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